中国茶

种类·泡法·茶馆·茶马古道

Tea in China

Kinds of Tea · Brewing · Teahouses · The Tea Horse Road

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 茶是中国人生活中很重要的一部分。不管是在家里、办公室还是饭馆，你都常常能看到一杯热茶。很多人早上起床以后的第一件事就是泡[†]一杯茶。中国是世界上最早种茶和喝茶的国家，今天世界上很多语言里表示“茶”的词，都是从汉语来的。下面我们来介绍一下中国的茶：茶的历史、种类、泡茶的方法、茶馆[‡]文化，还有一条有名的古代“茶路”。

茶的历史

2 关于茶的来源，有一个古老[§]的传说。传说几千年前，有一位叫神农[¶]的人，他尝[*]了很多种植物，想知道哪些可以吃，哪些可以做药。有一天，几片树叶掉进了他的热水[#]里，水的颜色变了，喝起来又香又苦，喝完以后他觉得很舒服。

† 泡 *pào* to steep, to brew
‡ 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
§ 古老 *gǔlǎo* ancient, old
¶ 神农 *Shénnóng* Shennong, legendary ruler and herbalist
* 尝 *cháng* to taste
\# 热水 *rèshuǐ* hot water

Tea is a very important part of Chinese people's lives. Whether at home, in the office or in a restaurant, you will often see a cup of hot tea. For many people, the first thing they do after getting up in the morning is to make a cup of tea. China was the first country in the world to grow and drink tea, and in many of the world's languages today the word for "tea" comes from Chinese. Below we introduce Chinese tea: its history, its kinds, how to brew it, teahouse culture, and a famous ancient "tea road". 1

A Short History of Tea

There is an old legend about the origin of tea. It is said that thousands of years ago a man called Shennong tasted many kinds of plants to find out which could be eaten and which could be used as medicine. One day a few leaves fell into his hot water. The water changed colour and tasted both fragrant and bitter, and after drinking it he felt very well. 2

这就是人们说的第一杯茶。当然，这只是一个传说，但是它说明茶在中国的历史非常长。

一开始，人们主要把茶当作[1]药。后来，喝茶慢慢变成了一种日常习惯。到了唐朝[2]，喝茶在全国都非常流行。唐朝有一个叫陆羽[3]的人，他一生都在研究茶。他去过很多地方，了解不同地方的茶树[4]、做茶的方法和喝茶的习惯，最后写成了一本书，叫《茶经[5]》。这是世界上第一本专门介绍茶的书，所以后来人们叫他“茶圣[6]”。

宋朝[7]的时候，人们喜欢把茶叶磨[8]成粉[9]，再用热水[10]打出很多白色的泡沫[11]，有时候还会比赛，看谁的茶最好。这种喝茶的方法后来传到了日本，对日本的茶道[12]有很大的影响。

1 当作 *dàngzuò* to treat as
2 唐朝 *Tángcháo* the Tang dynasty (618–907)
3 陆羽 *Lù Yǔ* Lu Yu (733–804), tea scholar
4 茶树 *cháshù* tea plant
5 茶经 *Chájīng* The Classic of Tea
6 茶圣 *Chá Shèng* the Sage of Tea
7 宋朝 *Sòngcháo* the Song dynasty (960–1279)
8 磨 *mó* to grind
9 粉 *fěn* powder
10 热水 *rèshuǐ* hot water
11 泡沫 *pàomò* foam, froth
12 茶道 *chádào* the way of tea, tea ceremony

That, people say, was the first cup of tea. Of course, this is only a legend, but it shows how long tea's history in China is. 2

At first, people mainly used tea as a medicine. Later, tea drinking gradually became an everyday habit. By the Tang dynasty, tea drinking was very popular all over the country. In the Tang dynasty there lived a man named Lu Yu, who spent his whole life studying tea. He travelled to many places to learn about their tea plants, their ways of making tea and their tea-drinking customs, and finally wrote a book called The Classic of Tea. It was the world's first book devoted entirely to tea, and so people later called him the "Sage of Tea". 3

In the Song dynasty people liked to grind tea leaves into powder and then whisk it with hot water into a white froth. Sometimes they even held contests to see whose tea was best. This way of drinking tea later spread to Japan, where it had a great influence on the Japanese tea ceremony. 4

4 到了明朝[1]，人们才开始像今天一样，直接用热水[2]泡[3]茶叶。

茶的种类

5 中国的茶有很多种。最常见的分法是按照做茶的方法，把茶分成[4]六大类：绿茶、白茶[5]、黄茶[6]、青茶[7]、红茶和黑茶[8]。这些茶都来自同[9]一种茶树[10]，不同的是做法。茶叶摘[11]下来以后，会跟空气发生变化，这个过程叫“发酵[12]”。发酵得越多，茶的颜色一般就越深，味道也越浓。

6 绿茶是中国人喝得最多的茶。它几乎没有发酵，所以茶水是浅绿色的，味道清新[13]。

1 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
2 热水 *rèshuǐ* hot water
3 泡 *pào* to steep, to brew
4 分成 *fēnchéng* to divide into
5 白茶 *báichá* white tea
6 黄茶 *huángchá* yellow tea
7 青茶 *qīngchá* oolong tea
8 黑茶 *hēichá* dark (post-fermented) tea
9 同 *tóng* same
10 茶树 *cháshù* tea plant
11 摘 *zhāi* to pick
12 发酵 *fājiào* fermentation (here: oxidation)
13 清新 *qīngxīn* fresh, light

Only in the Ming dynasty did people begin, as they do today, to steep the leaves directly in hot water. 4

Kinds of Tea

China has many kinds of tea. The most common way to classify them is by how the tea is made, which gives six large groups: green, white, yellow, oolong, black and dark tea. All of them come from the same tea plant; what differs is how they are made. After the leaves are picked, they react with the air; this process is called "fermentation" (strictly speaking, oxidation). The more a tea is oxidised, the darker its colour usually is, and the stronger its flavour. 5

Green tea is the tea Chinese people drink most. It is hardly oxidised at all, so the tea is pale green and tastes fresh and light. 6

6 杭州[1]的龙井[2]和江苏[3]的碧螺春[4]都是很有名的绿茶。泡[5]绿茶的时候，水不要太热，八十度左右就可以了，不然茶叶会被烫[6]坏，喝起来会有点儿苦。

7 青茶[7]也叫乌龙茶[8]，它的发酵[9]程度在绿茶和红茶之间。福建和台湾[10]都出产很好的乌龙茶，福建的铁观音[11]和大红袍[12]都非常有名。乌龙茶的香味[13]很特别，有的像花，有的像水果，而且可以泡很多次。

8 红茶在英语里不叫“red tea”，而叫“black tea”，这是因为外国人看的是茶叶的颜色，而中国人看的是茶水的颜色。红茶是全发酵的茶，味道比较浓，可以加牛奶和糖。中国最有名的红茶之一是安徽[14]的祁门[15]红茶。

1 杭州 *Hángzhōu* Hangzhou
2 龙井 *Lóngjǐng* Longjing (Dragon Well) green tea
3 江苏 *Jiāngsū* Jiangsu (province)
4 碧螺春 *Bìluóchūn* Biluochun green tea
5 泡 *pào* to steep, to brew
6 烫 *tàng* to scald
7 青茶 *qīngchá* oolong tea
8 乌龙茶 *wūlóngchá* oolong tea
9 发酵 *fājiào* fermentation (here: oxidation)
10 台湾 *Táiwān* Taiwan
11 铁观音 *Tiěguānyīn* Tieguanyin oolong tea
12 大红袍 *Dàhóngpáo* Da Hong Pao (“Big Red Robe”) oolong
13 香味 *xiāngwèi* fragrance
14 安徽 *Ānhuī* Anhui (province)
15 祁门 *Qímén* Qimen (Keemun)

Longjing (Dragon Well) from Hangzhou and Biluochun from Jiangsu are both famous green teas. When brewing green tea, the water should not be too hot; about eighty degrees is enough. Otherwise the leaves get scalded and the tea tastes a little bitter. 6

Qingcha is also called oolong; its degree of oxidation lies between that of green and black tea. Fujian and Taiwan both produce excellent oolong; Tieguanyin and Da Hong Pao from Fujian are both very famous. Oolong has a very special fragrance – some smell like flowers, some like fruit – and the same leaves can be steeped many times. 7

In English, hongcha is not called "red tea" but "black tea", because foreigners named it after the colour of the leaves, while Chinese people name it after the colour of the tea in the cup. Black tea is fully oxidised and has a fairly strong flavour, so milk and sugar can be added. One of China's most famous black teas is Keemun, from Qimen in Anhui. 8

9 黑茶[1]里最有名的是云南的普洱茶[2]。普洱茶常常被压成圆圆的茶饼[3]，可以放很多年。有的人认为，好的普洱茶就像好酒一样，放的时间越长，味道越好，所以老的普洱茶有时候非常贵。

10 白茶[4]和黄茶[5]比较少见[6]。白茶几乎不加工，摘[7]下来以后只是放着，让它慢慢变干，所以味道很淡。另外，中国人也喜欢喝花茶[8]，最常见的是茉莉花茶[9]，就是把茶叶和茉莉花[10]放在一起，让茶叶吸收花的香味[11]。在北方，特别是在北京，茉莉花茶非常受欢迎。

1 黑茶 *hēichá* dark (post-fermented) tea
2 普洱茶 *Pǔ'ěrchá* Pu'er tea
3 茶饼 *chábǐng* tea cake (pressed tea)
4 白茶 *báichá* white tea
5 黄茶 *huángchá* yellow tea
6 少见 *shǎojiàn* rare
7 摘 *zhāi* to pick
8 花茶 *huāchá* flower-scented tea
9 茉莉花茶 *mòlìhuāchá* jasmine tea
10 茉莉花 *mòlìhuā* jasmine flowers
11 香味 *xiāngwèi* fragrance

The best-known dark tea is Pu'er from Yunnan. Pu'er is often pressed into round tea cakes, which can be kept for many years. Some people believe that good Pu'er is like good wine: the longer it is kept, the better it tastes, which is why old Pu'er can be very expensive. 9

White and yellow teas are less common. White tea is hardly processed at all: after picking, the leaves are simply left to dry slowly, so its taste is very delicate. Chinese people also like scented teas. The most common is jasmine tea, made by putting tea leaves together with jasmine flowers so that the leaves absorb their fragrance. In the north, and especially in Beijing, jasmine tea is very popular. 10

怎么泡[1]茶

11 在中国，泡茶的方法很多，最简单的是用杯子泡：在杯子里放一些茶叶，然后倒进热水[2]，等两三分钟就可以喝了。很多上班的人每天早上都会这样泡一大杯茶，一直喝到下午，水少了就再加热水。

12 如果想好好品[3]茶，人们会用一种更讲究的方法，叫“功夫茶[4]”。功夫茶来自中国南方的福建和广东，特别是潮汕[5]地区。泡功夫茶需要一套小小的茶具[6]：一个小茶壶[7]或者盖碗[8]，几个只能装一两口茶的小杯子，还有一个茶盘[9]。

13 泡功夫茶的时候，先用热水把茶壶和杯子烫[10]一遍，让它们变热。

1 泡 *pào* to steep, to brew
2 热水 *rèshuǐ* hot water
3 品 *pǐn* to savour
4 功夫茶 *gōngfuchá* gongfu tea
5 潮汕 *Cháoshàn* Chaoshan (region in eastern Guangdong)
6 茶具 *chájù* tea set, tea ware
7 茶壶 *cháhú* teapot
8 盖碗 *gàiwǎn* lidded bowl (gaiwan)
9 茶盘 *chápán* tea tray
10 烫 *tàng* to scald

How to Brew Tea

There are many ways to brew tea in China. The simplest is to brew it in a glass: put in some leaves, pour in hot water, wait two or three minutes, and it is ready to drink. Many office workers make a big glass of tea like this every morning and keep drinking it until the afternoon, topping it up with hot water whenever it runs low. 11

If people want to really savour their tea, they use a more elaborate method called "gongfu tea". Gongfu tea comes from Fujian and Guangdong in southern China, especially the Chaoshan region. Brewing gongfu tea needs a small set of tea ware: a little teapot or a gaiwan (a lidded bowl), a few tiny cups that hold only a sip or two, and a tea tray. 12

To brew gongfu tea, you first rinse the teapot and cups with hot water to warm them up. 13

13 然后放进茶叶，倒进热水[1]，很快就把第一次的水倒掉，这叫“洗茶[2]”，可以让茶叶慢慢打开。接下来再倒进热水，等几秒钟[3]到半分钟，就把茶倒进杯子里，请客人喝。同样的茶叶可以泡[4]很多次，每一次的味道都有一点儿不同。

14 喝功夫茶[5]的时候，人们不是大口大口地喝，而是一小口一小口地慢慢品[6]。先看茶的颜色，再闻茶的香味[7]，最后才喝。很多人说，功夫茶的“功夫”不只是指泡茶的技术，也是指愿意花时间、慢下来的心情。

1 热水 *rèshuǐ* hot water
2 洗茶 *xǐchá* rinsing the tea
3 秒钟 *miǎozhōng* second (of time)
4 泡 *pào* to steep, to brew
5 功夫茶 *gōngfuchá* gongfu tea
6 品 *pǐn* to savour
7 香味 *xiāngwèi* fragrance

Then you put in the leaves, pour in hot water and quickly pour this first water away. This is called "rinsing the tea", and it lets the leaves begin to open. Next you pour in hot water again, wait from a few seconds to half a minute, then pour the tea into the cups for the guests. The same leaves can be steeped many times, and each round tastes a little different. 13

People don't gulp gongfu tea; they savour it slowly, one small sip at a time. First they look at its colour, then smell its aroma, and only then drink. Many say that the "gongfu" in gongfu tea refers not only to the skill of brewing, but also to a willingness to take time and slow down. 14

茶馆[1]和待客

15 在中国，茶馆是一个很重要的地方。以前，茶馆就像今天的咖啡馆一样，人们在那里喝茶、聊天、谈生意，也听人讲故事、唱戏[2]。在成都[3]，很多老人每天早上都去茶馆，坐在竹[4]椅子上，一边喝茶，一边和朋友聊天，一坐就是一个上午。在广州[5]，人们喜欢去茶楼[6]“饮茶[7]”，除了茶以外，还会吃很多小点心[8]，比如虾饺[9]和叉烧包[10]。

16 茶也是中国人待客的重要方式。客人来到家里，主人做的第一件事常常就是给客人倒一杯茶。倒茶的时候，一般不要倒得太满，因为太满的茶杯很烫[11]，客人不好拿，所以人们常说“茶满欺人[12]”。人们一般只倒七八分满。

1 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
2 戏 *xì* (Chinese) opera
3 成都 *Chéngdū* Chengdu
4 竹 *zhú* bamboo
5 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
6 茶楼 *chálóu* teahouse restaurant
7 饮茶 *yǐnchá* “drinking tea”: a Cantonese dim sum meal
8 点心 *diǎnxin* dim sum, snacks
9 虾饺 *xiājiǎo* shrimp dumplings
10 叉烧包 *chāshāobāo* barbecued pork buns
11 烫 *tàng* to scald
12 茶满欺人 *chá mǎn qī rén* “a full cup of tea slights the guest”

Teahouses and Hospitality

In China, the teahouse is a very important place. In the past, teahouses were like today's cafés: people went there to drink tea, chat and do business, and also to listen to storytellers and opera singers. In Chengdu many old people go to the teahouse every morning, sit on bamboo chairs drinking tea and chatting with friends, and stay the whole morning. In Guangzhou people like to go to teahouse restaurants for yum cha, "drinking tea" – which besides tea means eating lots of small dim sum dishes, such as shrimp dumplings and barbecued pork buns. 15

Tea is also an important part of Chinese hospitality. When guests arrive at someone's home, the first thing the host does is often to pour them a cup of tea. When pouring tea, you shouldn't fill the cup too full, because a brimming cup is too hot for the guest to hold. That's why people say, "A full cup of tea slights the guest." Usually people fill it only seventy or eighty percent. 16

17 在广东和福建，还有一个有意思的习惯。别人给你倒茶的时候，你可以用两三个手指在桌子上轻轻敲[1]几下，表示“谢谢”。据说这个习惯和清朝[2]的乾隆[3]皇帝[4]有关[5]。传说乾隆有一次穿着普通人的衣服去南方旅行，在茶馆[6]里亲自给身边的人倒茶。身边的人不能跪[7]下来感谢皇帝，因为怕别人发现皇帝的身份，就用手指在桌子上敲了几下，代替跪下。

18 茶还有很多别的用处[8]。在传统的婚礼上，新娘和新郎要给父母敬茶[9]，表示尊敬[10]和感谢。年轻人做错了事情，有时候也会给长辈[11]倒一杯茶，表示道歉[12]。所以，一杯茶里，常常有很多说不出来的意思。

1 敲 *qiāo* to tap, to knock
2 清朝 *Qīngcháo* the Qing dynasty (1644–1912)
3 乾隆 *Qiánlóng* the Qianlong Emperor (r. 1735–1796)
4 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
5 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
6 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
7 跪 *guì* to kneel
8 用处 *yòngchu* use
9 敬茶 *jìngchá* to serve tea (as a mark of respect)
10 尊敬 *zūnjìng* to respect
11 长辈 *zhǎngbèi* elders
12 道歉 *dàoqiàn* to apologise

In Guangdong and Fujian there is another interesting custom. When someone pours tea for you, you can tap the table lightly a few times with two or three fingers to say "thank you". This custom is said to go back to the Qianlong Emperor of the Qing dynasty. Legend has it that Qianlong once travelled in the south dressed as an ordinary man, and in a teahouse he poured tea for his companions himself. His companions could not kneel to thank the emperor, for fear that others would discover who he was, so they tapped their fingers on the table a few times instead of kneeling. 17

Tea has many other uses too. At a traditional wedding, the bride and groom serve tea to their parents to show respect and gratitude. When young people have done something wrong, they sometimes pour a cup of tea for their elders as an apology. So a single cup of tea often carries many meanings that go unspoken. 18

茶马古道[1]

19 在中国西南部，有一条很有名的古代商路，叫“茶马古道”。它从四川[2]和云南出发，经过很高很险[3]的山，一直通到西藏[4]，有的路还通到了尼泊尔[5]和印度。这条路已经有一千多年的历史了。

20 为什么叫“茶马古道”呢？因为在这条路上，人们主要用茶来换马。西藏的人们住在很高的地方，天气很冷，平时吃很多肉和奶，很少吃蔬菜[6]，所以他们需要喝茶来帮助消化。而中原[7]地区需要好马，特别是在打仗[8]的时候。所以，两边的人就用茶换马，这种交易叫“茶马互市[9]”。

21 在这条路上运[10]茶非常辛苦[11]。

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1 茶马古道 *Chá-Mǎ Gǔdào* the Tea Horse Road
2 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan (province)
3 险 *xiǎn* dangerous, steep
4 西藏 *Xīzàng* Tibet
5 尼泊尔 *Níbó'ěr* Nepal
6 蔬菜 *shūcài* vegetables
7 中原 *Zhōngyuán* the Central Plains (heartland of China)
8 打仗 *dǎzhàng* to go to war
9 茶马互市 *chá-mǎ hùshì* the tea-for-horses trade
10 运 *yùn* to carry, to transport
11 辛苦 *xīnkǔ* hard, toilsome

The Tea Horse Road

In southwest China there is a famous ancient trade route called the "Tea Horse Road". It set out from Sichuan and Yunnan, crossed very high and dangerous mountains and led all the way to Tibet; some routes went on as far as Nepal and India. The road has a history of more than a thousand years. 19

Why is it called the "Tea Horse Road"? Because along this road, people mainly traded tea for horses. The people of Tibet live at high altitude in a cold climate. They usually eat a lot of meat and dairy and few vegetables, so they need tea to help their digestion. China's heartland, meanwhile, needed good horses, especially in times of war. So the two sides exchanged tea for horses, a trade known as the "tea-horse market". 20

Carrying tea along this road was extremely hard work. 21

21 很多路又窄[1]又陡[2]，只能走人和马，人们用马或者自己的背把一包一包的茶运[3]过去。为了方便运输，茶叶常常被压成很硬[4]的砖[5]，叫“砖茶[6]”。一次旅行常常要走好几个月，路上要经过高山[7]、大河和雪地，非常危险。今天，这条路的很多地方已经修了公路，但是还有一些老路和古镇[8]留了下来，吸引了很多游客。

22 今天，西藏[9]人还是很喜欢喝酥油茶[10]。酥油茶是用砖茶、酥油[11]和盐做的，喝起来有点儿咸，可以让身体变暖[12]，还能补充能量[13]。从一杯酥油茶里，我们还能看到那条古老[14]商路留下的影子。

1 窄 *zhǎi* narrow
2 陡 *dǒu* steep
3 运 *yùn* to carry, to transport
4 硬 *yìng* hard
5 砖 *zhuān* brick
6 砖茶 *zhuānchá* brick tea
7 高山 *gāoshān* high mountain
8 古镇 *gǔzhèn* old town
9 西藏 *Xīzàng* Tibet
10 酥油茶 *sūyóuchá* butter tea
11 酥油 *sūyóu* yak butter
12 暖 *nuǎn* warm
13 能量 *néngliàng* energy
14 古老 *gǔlǎo* ancient, old

Many paths were narrow and steep, passable only by people and horses, so 21
the tea was carried across bundle by bundle, on horseback or on people's own backs. To make transport easier, the leaves were often pressed into hard bricks known as "brick tea". A single journey often took several months, crossing high mountains, big rivers and snowfields, and it was very dangerous. Today roads have been built along much of the route, but some old paths and ancient towns survive and attract many visitors.

Tibetans today still love to drink butter tea. Butter tea is made from brick 22
tea, yak butter and salt. It tastes a little salty, warms the body and gives you energy. In a cup of butter tea, we can still see a trace of that ancient trade route.

结语

23 从古代的药，到今天的日常饮料[1]；从皇帝[2]的宫殿[3]，到普通人的小茶馆[4]，茶已经陪伴[5]了中国人几千年。今天，中国的年轻人也喝奶茶、喝咖啡，可是在很多家庭里，一壶[6]热茶还是最常见的东西。下次你喝茶的时候，可以慢一点儿，闻一闻，品[7]一品，也许你会发现，一杯简单的茶里有很多故事。

1 饮料 *yǐnliào* drink, beverage
2 皇帝 *huángdì* emperor
3 宫殿 *gōngdiàn* palace
4 茶馆 *cháguǎn* teahouse
5 陪伴 *péibàn* to accompany
6 壶 *hú* pot (measure word)
7 品 *pǐn* to savour

In Closing

From an ancient medicine to an everyday drink, from emperors' palaces 23
to ordinary people's little teahouses, tea has kept the Chinese company for thousands of years. Young Chinese people today also drink milk tea and coffee, but in many homes a pot of hot tea is still the most familiar thing of all. Next time you drink tea, slow down a little, smell it and savour it. Perhaps you will discover that a simple cup of tea holds many stories.